Abkhazia or Crimea. The costs of Russia's imperialist aspirations grow even more if we consider that the main geopolitical proposal offered by Putin since 2012 has been the launch of an Eurasian Economic Union (EEU), which might, at least, provide solid institutional trappings for a closer economic and political integration of the post-Soviet region and, at most, could match Putin's grand vision for a Russian-led reorganisation of that space (Putin 2012). Implementing this plan and consolidating it as the preferred alternative to the EU in the post-Soviet space has become a priority, whatever the costs (and they will be high).

The EEU is, since 1 January 2015, an official working reality, comprising Russia, Kazakhstan and Belarus, with Kyrgyzstan set to join in coming months. Unlike the Commonwealth of Independent States (CIS) before it, the EEU has a clearer institutional structure and builds from several other organisations such as the Eurasian Economic Union, the Customs Union and, more recently, the Eurasian Economic Commission. Modelled loosely on the EU (replicating the morphology of some of its organs, with the obvious exception of a Eurasian Parliament), the EEU seeks to provide a more inclusive, efficient and articulate integration between its members, but, in so doing, it will ensure that its members continue, as much as possible, within Moscow's orbit (Popescu 2014; on the emphasis on parallelisms with the EU, see Putin 2012). Moscow's proposals for the EEU are in this sense quite novel. The use of coercion or direct violence in what it regards as its sphere of influence has proven risky and counterproductive (it has already derailed previous attempts at unifying the post-Soviet space), so the EEU is presented with the reassurance that each member will retain its full sovereignty. This move also reflects a further change in Russian foreign policy thinking: the foreign policy documents of 2000, 2008 and 2013 all highlight the importance of cooperation with the 'near abroad', and the last two gravitate away from the emphasis on security and towards deeper economic integration (for a useful comparative review, see Ruiz Gonzalez 2013).

This new attempt at creating an economic space offers clearer collective benefits (though the main beneficiary is of course Russia) around an institution which proceeds from parliamentary ratification of the founding treaty by each of its members and which offers a rotating frame for decision-making operating by consensus (Popescu 2014:11–13). Through the EEU, Russia also hopes to begin clawing back its commercial position in the region, threatened increasingly by both the EU and China – Russia is currently the biggest trading partner only for Belarus and Uzbekistan. Further, the EEU abolishes internal barriers to trade and sets a common external tariff at a level agreed upon by Russia and the WTO on the former's accession (10%). Critically, this move benefits Russia